

Marcella Houston
Your Rooms and Their Melodies

Future Retro

You are inside a room.

Two walls are completely adorned with amps, and the ceiling is only partially built. Steel girders act as if they're supporting something, but any purpose other than visual still eludes you. You have never seen an exit to this room and there is no life in it, but that's not to say you should fear the room: this room is not the unknown. The room is safe. You know you're going to have a retrospective in the nearest future.

The instruments slowly turn on, echoing a noise similar to fluorescent lights in a warehouse. Finally, after enough anticipation, the instruments perform their song automatically, but that does not mean you do nothing in the rooms. The rooms perform for you, but you must perform for the rooms, too, just as always.

Just what are "rooms," "instruments," and "melodies" anyway? Are they the things that give your life purpose, or do they take it away? Maybe even both.

You're reminded that words can change meaning from room to room.

Aqua Harp

You wade in an endless pool, ankle-deep and at night,
encompassed by an aurora of glass

None of these rooms are scary. This one, however, is the only one with deliberate dismay. You question if this is even a room—you feel exposed because there is no ceiling and the walls are glass, and beyond the walls is blackness. How can it be that you feel like anything could see you, but you could not see anything?

The only thing inside the room other than shallow water is the aqua harp: a curved, tall, and broad instrument amalgam. The main portion resembles a rustic, wooden frame supporting vertical musical strings. Atop the frame are whistles, one above each string. On either side of the frame is one additional string for violinist fiddling instead of harpist strumming. Below the frame are purple tubular bells, melancholic as they are resounding. You see the whole instrument and may even see a reason why the aqua harp exists, but you are quickly desponded by its predictable melody.

Every other room is full of goofy joy, so why do you choose to stay in the premise of the aqua harp? Perhaps the room is your bottle, and you're shattering it. Perhaps acknowledging the aqua harp prevents destruction. Perhaps you just want the other rooms to know that sadness exists in the world.

Acoustic Curves

You question the logistics of a room with no ceiling or floor

It's completely empty, too. How is there light here, anyway? Why is this room so unconventional? Are all rooms like this? You thought your room was the only one.

Suddenly a curved instrument rises from the bottomless pit, all by itself, and plays a discordant melody. The melody means nothing to you, yet clearly it means everything to the acoustic instrument. Another curve rises from the void and synchronizes to the first curve, making a modest melody with some semblance of rhythm, but it still cannot compare to orchestras you've witnessed in other rooms: with your friends. You're unimpressed until a third curve and a drum set materialize. The drums may not resemble the curves, but it compliments them perfectly. Their collective hymns to one another finally begin sounding like those orchestras, and you can't help but feel happy for them. As if the moment couldn't get any more beautiful, one final curve and a ring of tubular bells tie the bow on the package, saying, "We are one." You start to feel like "one." You're an instrument now—matriculated into the clique.

But then the curves, drums, and bells depart as the song ends, receding into the void they emerged from. You suddenly feel like you deserve a say in the matter: why disband the orchestra? All the instruments' melodies coalesced into a cacophony of fun, so why break that fun? If only you could capture the instruments by installing a ceiling and a floor, but this world has no ceilings or floors. The brief moment of ecstasy has passed. That melody meant everything to you.

Pogo Sticks

You walk an endlessly-long, twisting road among other roads

There are many roads visible from your location, but you have no clue if they are truly different roads or if they all connect to your road somewhere invisible in the horizon. You can't stray from your road to check either, for between roads are untraversable wooden pillars speckled and rotated recklessly. You always stay on the road because only hooligans step off it, and they pay the price.

There were instruments here, but you were too slow—they pogoed happily and swiftly away on their road with confidence. Together. Do you know anyone on your road? Do you know anything about your road?

This is still a room, only one without walls and with a sky. This is the room you go to when you ask yourself why you're doing something. The music here is of little importance—you're interested in the ambience. You could trip if you ran along your road too fast.

This poem is on a road. You know where the road ends, but I don't. The world is vast. You swore you *chose* your road, but it's hard to tell if that's true when the road can feel more like a conveyor belt at times.

Resonant Chamber

You tweak an apparatus centered in a room

No, wait, that's an instrument. Some sort of guitar of guitars. Playing it would be impossible, you deem, without an individual finger for the hundreds of strings on it, all crossed and overlapping, some horizontal and some slanted.

You're inside a cozy, wood chamber with a window. It's confusing, but the window doesn't lead to outside the room. It instead leads to the sky and the moon, which are part of this room. Every time you peek out the window at the moon, it has a different phase. You thought the moon was more predictable than that. Are you like the moon?

You don't play the instrument because the instrument plays itself. The guitar of guitars doesn't take kindly when you try to tweak it, but it also doesn't tell you when it tweaks itself. You look out the window, and apparently your favorite color changed without your permission. Sometimes, you realize your guitar of guitars tweaked itself like that. It's resounding, for it never stops.

The guitar of guitars feels very personal to you, but for some reason you don't understand it. This room is you, yet it makes no sense. Another peek out the window and you no longer like your favorite food. The unconventional, automatic melody of the instrument changes the phase of the moon. You realize that you aren't you anymore, but that's a good thing, you conclude. Hopefully others see it as a good thing, too. It would be unfair if they were to judge you based on the compulsory actions of the guitar of guitars in your head.

Heavy Light

You reflect on your time in the other rooms;

This room is a stage on a gargantuan altar or monument so large you've never seen the bottom of it. You hesitate calling the devices that play sound here "instruments" because they act differently from the instruments in other rooms. Their grand tune solicits a more meta retrospective.

Instead of pondering your time outside of rooms, you think back upon what insight you received from the previous rooms. The champion melody makes it easy to do so, for it feels final. That's silly though—you're still young, and that's why you came to the rooms. In a way, though, Heavy Light is a finale. It's a finale to your current visit to the rooms, and it will be a finale the next time you visit the rooms, but that also means it's still *not* a finale. You don't have to give the rooms meaning today. They age as you age. Do you hope to give them all meaning during your lifespan, or will you choose to ignore some?

I said that rooms aren't scary, but sometimes we perceive them as frightening. What if someone ignores your aqua harp or mocks your road? We may unfortunately ignore rooms because of questions like those.

Next time, you might have more rooms or less rooms. You might call them different names. The very definition of "instrument" might change in rooms that otherwise stay the same. It's natural. But for now, you relax yourself to the victory lap of Heavy Light. You congratulate yourself for acknowledging your problems.

The sections of this poem are titled after tracks in the computer-animated video albums Animusic and Animusic 2, created by Animusic, LLC

▶ Animusic 1 & 2

